

It is important to maintain a level of transparency with the community and keep it in the loop. The community can get involved at any step that it wants to. It's really important that you show most of your work to the community while you are doing it, apart from things that need to be done confidentially, like setting up security, signing certificates, branding, and so on. This helps in winning its trust because, in the end, it is the community that you are liable to, and it can make or break your project. This may make the project work a lot more deliberate, slower and exposed, but it works well in the end.

Making your work-in-progress so open can seem daunting, especially when you are worried about the repercussions of a delay in updates or having a bug. Yet, making the community members privy to your moves will not only help you build a trustful relationship with them, but also make them feel appreciated.

However, making your workflow public will also invite scrutiny from the community members, who will often have their opinions and offer you their feedback. Taking note of this feedback is important, because that is how you can make your open source project truly for them. They are the end users and their feedback will reflect how they see your project panning out for them in the long run, and ultimately, how successful and mainstream your software becomes.

As an example, when we are thinking about a new feature, we publish a request for comments at RFC. We get a lot of feedback, and we have to think hard about how we can incorporate it.

Since open source is a largely collaborative work, there will be initiatives by the community to offer their support in making the project the best version possible. Not all of it will work out. But as long you are listening, the community will feel involved.

Building a community always has its highs and lows. Let me list some of the tricks that helped maintain a healthy balance between the community's and my team's vision.

State your principle: Especially in the early stage of the open source project when the source code is still coming together and things are not exactly going perfectly, it is hard for somebody coming from outside to really understand why you are making the decisions that you are making. Communicating the principles on which you take actions helps you to be upfront about your thought process so that the community does not interpret things incorrectly.

This practice is really helpful. It is also important to follow through and show that when you make a decision, it is guided by one of these principles.

Decide how you are going to collaborate: This may be through channels like Discord, Slack, or simply emails. But if you try to use all of them, you will immediately diffuse the community. People will be communicating with each other all over the place. Choose one or two collaboration tools, and really invest in them for synchronised communication.

Treasure the feedback: Listen to feedback from the community and act on it. Show that you care about what the community says, even if it requires you to make tough decisions.

Maintain a code of conduct: If you interact with a community, you need to define what is going to be acceptable conduct. Having that in place helps warn people in case they go out of line. You can avoid a lot of trouble if you can just define this early on.

Think about how you will distribute your project: There may be instances when you may not be willing to make your project available to the public because you do not have a certain component in place, or you have features you may not want to make accessible to everyone. Creating distribution terms that suit your preference without compromising on what the user wants is key, so that people who want certain features can access these while those who can do without them also have the option to start using the project without having to compromise.

Avoid polls as much as you can: This is because, often, certain members vote for an option that may not be what the majority goes with. This can create a sense of failure in these members and make them feel excluded from the project. Instead, try asking them what problems they would like to be solved, and then try to invent a solution that does not involve trade-offs.

Engaging with the community has its pitfalls too. There may be differences of opinion within the community, and also between the maintainer and the community, especially when it comes to the matter of governance. Governance is something which is really important for an open source project to have. That is why it is important to have clear documented governance practices, which also include the community.

Community governance is a tough, but essential, nut to crack. Delegation in itself requires a lot of trust. For a project with millions of lines of code, it can be cumbersome to find someone in the community who can meaningfully lead it. But open source projects often consist of smaller sub-projects, which are better left handled by someone from the community. This helps the community to be more closely involved too.